MISSION ARCHITECT TOOLKIT / SESSION 606

THE MISSION ARCHITECT'S FIELD GUIDE

Start with performance. Make the thinking playable.



FIVE STEPS FROM WORKPLACE NEED TO LEARNING GAME

01	**FIND THE PERFORMANCE GAP**	Where are people struggling, and is practice an appropriate response? **OUTPUT: A behavior worth practicing**
02	**MAKE SUCCESS OBSERVABLE**	Given which information, what action will learners take, and what counts as correct? **OUTPUT: A measurable objective and success criteria**
03	**CHOOSE MECHANIC + STORY**	Choose an action that requires the target thinking, then add role, problem, and stakes. **OUTPUT: A playable concept and meaningful story**
04	**BUILD THE CHALLENGE**	Create the evidence, rules, artifacts, and answer key; test with a fresh solver. **OUTPUT: A playable, verified prototype**
05	**DESIGN FEEDBACK + TRANSFER**	Plan self-checks, hints, debrief, recovery, and a new situation to test the skill. **OUTPUT: A feedback and transfer plan**

BACKUP LEAGUE EXAMPLE: MEMORY MELTDOWN

Players examine six fictional incident reports, identify the three highest-priority emergencies, and sequence them using risk and timing criteria. Correctly arranged card backs reveal a verification message, and successfully completing the chapter earns a star-chart fragment for the final rescue puzzle.

DESIGN RULE: Could someone win without using the target behavior? If yes, redesign the interaction. A theme supplies purpose and stakes. The mechanic should require the same thinking that learners need beyond the game.

YOUR FIRST MISSION / QUICK DESIGN CANVAS

Use these four questions to sketch a five-minute prototype or start a fuller design canvas.

TASK

What decision or skill must people practice?

SUCCESS

What would observable success look like?

MECHANIC

What must players sort, compare, sequence, route, or assemble?

FEEDBACK

How will players get help and understand why they are right?

THE FIVE-MINUTE NOVICE TEST

- ☐ Can someone start without an oral explanation from the designer?
- ☐ Can a player reach and justify the intended solution using only the supplied evidence?
- ☐ Can they self-check, request a hint, and recover in time?
- ☐ Do instructions stay readable and usable with the actual room, group, and devices?
- ☐ Can you ask a new scenario or debrief question to check learning beyond the activity?

END WITH A QUICK DEBRIEF

Don't stop at revealing the correct answer. Ask players to explain their reasoning and connect the experience to a real-world situation. Try asking: "What evidence guided your decision? Why did you choose that approach? Where could you apply similar thinking outside the game?"

AI ATTRIBUTION Artwork generated with OpenAI tools; AI-assisted text reviewed and edited by the author.